

# SWEET HOURS

POEMS

BY

CARMEN SYLVA

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# **SWEET HOURS**

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CARMEN SYLVA  
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# TO THE MEMORY OF QUEEN VICTORIA



THESE ever wakeful eyes are closed. They saw  
Such grief, that they could see no more. The heart—  
That quick'ning pulse of nations—could not bear  
Another throb of pain, and could not hear  
Another cry of tortur'd motherhood.  
Those uncomplaining lips, they sob no more  
The soundless sobs of dark and burning tears,  
That none have seen; they smile no more, to breathe  
A mother's comfort into aching hearts.  
The patriarchal Queen, the monument  
Of touching widowhood, of endless love,  
And childlike purity—she sleeps. This night  
Is watchful not. The restless hand, that slave  
To duty, to a mastermind, to wisdom  
That fathom'd history and saw beyond  
The times, lies still in marble whiteness. Love  
So great, so faithful, unforgetting and  
Unselfish—must it sleep? Or will that veil,  
That widow's veil unfold, and spread into  
The dovelike wings, that long were wont to hover  
In anxious care about her world-wide nest,  
And now will soar and sing, as harpchords sing,  
Whilst in their upward flight they breast the wind  
Of Destiny. No rest for her, no tomb,  
Nor ashes! Light eternal! Hymns of joy!  
No silence now for her, who, ever silent,  
Above misfortunes' storms and thund'ring billows,  
Would stand with clear and fearless brow, so calm,  
That men drew strength from out those dauntless eyes,

And quiet from that hotly beating heart,  
Kept still by stern command and unbent will  
Beneath those tight shut lips. Not ashes, where  
A beacon e'er will burn, a fire, like  
The Altar's Soma, for the strong, the weak,  
The true, the brave, and for the quailing. No,  
Not ashes, but a light, that o'er the times  
Will shed a gentle ray, and show the haven,  
When all the world, stormshaken, rudderless, will pray:  
If but her century would shine again!  
Oh, Lord! Why hast thou ta'en thy peaceful Queen?

---

## A FRIEND



OLD age is gentle as an autumn morn;  
The harvest over, you will put the plough  
Into another, stronger hand, and watch  
The sowing you were wont to do.

Old age

Is like an alabaster room, with soft  
White curtains. All is light, but light so mild,  
So quiet, that it cannot hurt.

The pangs

Are hushed, for life is wild no more with strife,  
Nor breathless uphill work, nor heavy with  
The brewing tempests, which have torn away  
So much, that nothing more remains to fear.  
What once was hope, is gone. You know. You saw  
The worst, and not a sigh is left of all  
The heavy sighs that tore your heart, and not  
A tear of all those tears that burnt your cheeks,  
And ploughed the furrows into them.

You see

How others work again and weep again,  
And hope and fear. Thy alabaster room  
With marble floor and dainty hangings has  
A look so still, that others wonder why  
They feel it churchlike. All thy life is here;  
Thy life hath built the vault and paved it, and  
Thy hands have woven yonder curtains that  
Surround thy seat, a shady sunshine.

Age

Is feeble not to thee, as all thy wishes



Are silent and demand no effort. Age  
Is kind to thee, allows thee all the rest  
That never came, when life was hard and toilsome.  
Receive it with a smile and clothe thyself  
In white, in Nature's silver crown, and sing  
A lullaby of promise and of comfort.  
Tell them that life is precious, after work,  
And after grief and after all the deaths,  
And not a loathsome burden of a life.  
Old age is like a room of alabaster,  
The curtains silken; thou art priest and Druid!  
No mystery for thee, but Light from heaven!

---

# OUT OF THE DEEP



THY soul grows silent, when its accents are  
Disturbed, and low thy heart, when dark a burden  
Has deeply covered it. Thy soul is proud.  
When thou hast made it free of wants and wishes,  
Then art thou rich.

Our life is seldom open,  
For love and fear have shut it. When we lay  
It open, there is nought to show in it,  
But wounds and burning pain.

Mysterious is  
Thy power, great as it may be, a trial  
Of thine own will and of the curb upon  
Thyself; mysterious to thyself, the more,  
The greater it has grown, surrounded as  
We are by fear and pain.

And when the soul  
Lifts up her voice and speaks, then must she go  
Against the will of people, not her own,  
The will that is herself, the soul's own might.  
When heaven asks, we work with joy, a dear  
Beloved business put into our hands.  
We dream at first to make it daintily,  
Like Nature's work, so careful and so rich,  
And then the dream becomes a wish, then changes  
To action, to be called by us our own  
Free will. And when we feel alleviated  
Of suffering, we call it hope. In each  
Hard battle of our life, free will is quite  
The same, unbending and undone, and gave

Us never yet a ray of satisfaction,  
Nor of real joy, the bleeding conqueror.  
And hope is e'er the same. It dwelleth not  
In hearts that are too great for hope, too great  
For wishes, and that fearless never ask  
Why will is but obedience, power worthless,  
The greatest strength a reed, and thought an echo.  
Great hearts are free of either want or wish;  
They may be proud and richly clothe themselves  
In lofty, burdenless, mysterious Silence.

---

## A CORONATION



WHEN in Bohemia there were kings and queens,  
The crown was laid upon the head that had  
To bear and to exalt it—on the King's,  
And then upon the shoulder of the Queen.  
The shoulder bears the weight, the head the burden;  
The shoulder lifts, the head must carry. Great  
For both the heaviness, the endless pain,  
For both the thorns, for both hard labour, thankless  
Unending work, the sorrow of their people,  
The care of each and all, the scorching tears  
Of all, that make their path a desert, and  
Their robe so heavy, as if dew had changed  
Into the icy hangings of the frost.  
The shoulder oftentimes is wounded by  
The crown, the head bowed low, the heart so heavy,  
Much heavier than all that heavy weight,  
And yet doth woman's frail and bending shoulder  
Resist the load, and still her smiling eyes  
And gentle lips make all the world believe  
Her shoulder bleedeth not, her toil is easy,  
The load they put upon her without asking  
How great her strength, is like a toy. Oh, smile!  
Ye heavy-laden Queens! Let not a sigh  
Escape your loving hearts, and no complaint  
Break from the lips God made to heal and bless!  
Oh, smile! The world doth not forgive its slaves  
For looking overworked. If thou canst bear  
No more, then change the shoulder, tired Queen!

---



## DOWN THE STREAM



FROM whence the brook? From where the waters  
gather

In mountains' deep recesses, stone-black lakes  
And dripping crevices. It ripples forth  
Into the shining day with scarce a voice,  
And with no strength at all, till mountain showers  
And winter's snow and spring storms pour their flood  
Into the dancing brook, that foams and starts  
And rushes headlong down the steeps and throws  
Into the Unknown all its youth and strength,  
And thunders into hell, to rise again  
In sheets of whiteness into dreamy veils,  
To kiss the flowers' feet and overflow  
The meadows; thence, o'erbridged and caught and  
fastened

To wheels, to grind and grind with irksome noise,  
To lose all liberty, all winsome frolic,  
And work till doomsday. On and on the stream  
Goes widening into calm and mighty strength,  
A hero of a stream, that bears the ships  
Like toys, and carries legions.

Wider still

He grows, and stronger, as he drags the waters  
Of hundred rivers with him to the sea.  
At last his course is sluggish, tired, slow,  
A living death, till, blended with the sea,  
A rising tide will carry him away  
Into oblivion. Such is life! A stream  
From unknown heights through storm and dangerous fall,

Through unknown land and never-ending work  
Unto Eternity's great, unknown sea.  
You cannot rise above the height you come from,  
You only widen and expand—but downwards,—  
Your strength is gone, your impetus is quenched.  
And then the world will call you great and grand,  
And make a fortune out of all those waters:  
Your tears, your blood, your work, and what you spent;  
The strength of all your aims and all your falls!

---

## IN THE RUSHING WIND



THE wind hath whirled the leaves from off the tree.  
The leaves were yellow, they had lived their time,  
And lie a golden heap or fly away,  
As if the butterflies had left their wings  
Behind, when love's short summertime had gone,  
And killed them. Lightly doth the leaves' great shower  
Whirl on and skim the ground, where ancient leaves  
Lie rotten, trampled on, so featureless,  
That you can hardly tell what formed that mould,  
That never-ending burial-place of leaves.  
And then the wind will shake and bend the tree,  
And twist its branches off, burst it asunder,  
Uproot the giant and bring low his head,  
Upheave the granite block round which the roots  
Had taken hold for countless centuries.  
On goes the wind! The corn is green and soft—  
Earth's wavy fur. It does but ripple lightly  
In childish laughter at the harmless fun  
That was a death-blow. But the sea awakes  
And frowns and foams and rises into anger  
So wild with wrath, and yet so powerless,  
As if a thousand chains had chained it down,  
To howl, to suffer, to rebel against  
The heartless merriment of stronger powers.  
On goes the wind, to shake the rock, to blow  
Into a flame, the wild incendiary,  
And never doth he look behind, to see,  
To feel, to understand the horror he  
Hath worked. The breath—the robe of Destiny—



Sweeps on, sweeps past, and never lists that hell  
And heaven have awaked, in shrieking anguish,  
But blows the clouds away, laughs at the sun,  
And falls into unconscious, dreamless sleep.

---

# UNDER THE SNOW



**I** F green the corn and burning the volcano,  
Though snowclad, buried under rocks of ice,  
Why shall the heart not love and burn in waving  
Expectant green, or rising flames of hot  
Enthusiasm, or burst into a torrent  
Of wrath, though snow the summit long hath crowned?  
Behold! The field is green, the seed has risen  
That thou hast thrown into these aching furrows,  
Once ploughed by Destiny, and sown with sorrow  
And watered with the wells of tears, that dropped  
Upon each grain and flowed through all the furrows.  
They see the snow upon thine head, but not  
The corn and not the threat'ning furnace of  
Thy soul. They think it is extinct, they hope  
Thou hast forgotten, that the gentle warmth  
They feel is sunshine, not the stormy fire,  
That cannot cease to burn: for it remembers.

---

# SOLITUDE



THE greatest friend, the friend that dwells with thee,  
When the wild turmoil of the world is thrust  
Aside, when e'en thy smile may rest, that shield,  
That weapon, armour, gauntlet, laid aside,  
Will leave thy soul to sculpt thy features with  
Her own deep chisel; when before thyself  
Thou standest, as before thy judge and master,  
An outcry goeth forth from thee towards  
Thyself, then will great solitude enfold  
Thee, and her wings will hush the tempest.  
Fear not that angel's gravity, the look  
His searching eye will plunge into thy heart.  
Fear not the whisp'ring of his lips: Remember!  
For ev'ry word of thine, each working of  
Thy soul is booked, indelible the writing,  
It is encircled in the movement of  
The worlds and has its history. Thy soul,  
Itself a world, belongs to Solitude. It is  
So lonely that no crowd of friends, nor e'en  
One friend can take its loneliness away.  
There is but Solitude that can surround  
Thy soul with beings and thy heart with sight.  
It opens wide the floodgates of thy thought,  
And what the world repressed, hemmed in and stifled,  
Will rush like living waters through thy brain  
And sweep away the nothingness of things.  
Great Solitude will let thee listen. Hark!  
The voices of the Infinite are singing,  
The thoughts of thousands who have thought before thee

Come crowding round thy brain and fill the air,  
And seek a new expression on thy lips.  
Thou art in such ennobling company,  
That Solitude becomes the gorgeous feast,  
For which thy soul is clothed in white and purple,  
Thy feet unshod tread on the holy ground  
Where God has spoken. Hark! Great Solitude  
Hath thousand voices and a flood of light,  
Be not afraid, enter the Sanctuary,  
Thou wilt be taken by the hand and led  
To Life's own fountain, never-ending Thought!

---

## THE GNAT



A LONG-LEGGED gnat with airy wings, a dart  
Sharp as a needle and a searching tusk,  
Was flutt'ring round my lamp, clung to my book-shelf,  
And wandered over papers. Then I blew  
On it, to chase it far away. But no,  
Beneath the tempest of my breath it clung  
Still faster to the paper's slender shelter  
And moved not, till I thought my breath had killed it.  
We watched each other; then it flew away.  
I thought how Fate and we thus oftentimes watch  
Each other, till Fate blow us into atoms,  
And we remain in some weak place, in Death's  
Suspense, not knowing if again the storm  
Will blow. But Fate is careless and will let  
Us go, if but the wings that are to take  
Us hence are still untorn, unsinged, uncrushed;  
Or else we creep along and die unseen,  
A wingless worm, not understanding what  
Those papers and those shelves contain that are  
No revelation, nought but a grave, whilst others  
Suck life and food, from where the storm of Fate  
Hath torn us, unresisting, meaningless,  
And watching with an instant's careless glance,  
If we are really dead, or still may fly.  
Cheat cruel Fate, keep still like death, move not,  
Flutter not; then unfold thy wings, and go  
Thy way, the coming morn is full of life,  
Bury thy head in flowers, in the dew,  
The sun is rising and thou art alive!



## REST



AND did they say that rest was not so sweet,  
Old age a sadness, no repose at all?  
Then have they quite forgotten. They remember  
No more the heartbreak of their early youth,  
The battle fought for life, the angry clouds  
That hid the sun, till he would shine no more,  
The anguish of their nights, that made their bed  
A furnace and a rack. They say: 'Twas but  
A nightmare! And they smile, and yet that smile  
Is sadder than a frown, much sadder than  
A tear, as it is hopeless. For a tear  
Has a bright spot, wherein the sun may sparkle.  
That smile is sunless, be it e'er so sweet.  
And know ye not how wildly ye have called  
On Death, and tried to catch him by the wing,  
Or let yourself be trodden under foot  
By him? And wrung your hands in agony,  
When he had passed you by. Ye dare not tell  
Your heart what it has suffered, dare not look  
Into the past again, for fear of turning  
To stone, for whitelipp'd fear of waking from  
Its sleep that heart to make it throb again,  
Like millstones. You remember! Ah! You see!  
You even try to do away with pity,  
For fear of being tortured yet again,  
And shaken yet again, and no more able  
To quiet that unruly heart, that learnt  
To fear. Oh! Have ye never known what fear  
Can make of you? The wandering of your clock,

That hammers nails into your brain and hands,  
The coming of the dawn, that cruel dawn,  
With icy, deathlike eyes and hollow voice,  
Announcing mercilessly that the day  
Hath come? And were you not afraid, when night  
Set in again, with redhot eyeballs, with  
The lonely wringing of your soul between  
Her hands, like linen, that she washed in tears,  
In blood, in rivers of despair? Oh, see!  
Here comes with gentle wing and loving eye  
Sweet Rest, and lays her mantle round your shoulders,  
And bids you fear no more, but listen to  
The birds' first Alleluia to the morn,  
That dances o'er the dew, up to the dawn,  
And be it e'er so cold, so lifeless, like  
The last of all the dawn they sang to. Fear  
Is banished, anguish quenched in all the waters  
That grief has steeped you in. You know that ne'er  
Another day can be so dark again,  
As Rest forbids the cruel dawn to break  
With threat'ning eyes, as Rest shuts out the night,  
And leaves thee lonely not, but fills thy sight  
With loving faces at the gates of heaven.  
Sweet Rest is round thee, like an autumn sun,  
And sheds thy rays upon the striving young ones.  
Ye long for bed again, like little children;  
No longer doth the pillow seem on fire,  
Your couch a bed of coals. The weary head  
Is cool, the limbs lie still, and thought comes gently  
Like a nurse's well-known ditty, that will lull  
To sleep thee with its sameness. Rest hath come  
At last, and looks into thy room, into  
Thy heart, and sends forgetfulness, like balm,  
Like a flower's perfume through thy silent chamber.  
The clock is peaceful with its quiet beat,  
And night and morn are one; they bring no struggle.  
Sweet Rest hath come, great, wingèd, heaven-born,



To lead thee to thy home with angels' hands.



# THE SHADOW



THE shadow of your threshold is so full  
Of meaning, that the stranger knows what home  
Is yours, if peace dwell here, or strife, or restless  
Unsatisfied ambition. As the tree's  
Deep shadow meaneth rest and comfort, or  
Is poison, sleep eternal, such the house  
That is a home's sweet shadow or a dark  
Abode of sin, of lurking lie and danger.  
The shadow of your life, that is so small  
In bright midday and summer's burning sun,  
Begins to lengthen when your evening comes,  
And shows the beauty of the tree in outline,  
Its graceful forms, its harmony and power;  
And never did its beauty strike before,  
As now, when lost in thought, you contemplate  
The shadow on the lawn. The golden rays  
That flood it, make it higher, nobler, and  
Its shadow ever greater, till the night  
Calls forth the moon, to make it deep and weird  
As if unspoken pain had darkened it,  
As if the silvery paleness of the moon  
Sharpened its features into hardness almost.  
Behold the shadow of thy life! Look well if  
It be a threshold that reveals the strong  
Unbending will, the height of all your aims,  
Your passions' darkness, and the harmony  
Of all the branches that were put into  
Your care! Look at the shadow when your day  
Is done, and winter's moon will draw its line

In naked truth, without the flattering leaves  
Upon your windingsheet's unruffled snow.

---

# THE GLOWWORM



THE mountains lost in clouds, the giant firs  
Standing out 'gainst the never-ceasing lightning,  
Shaken by thunderpeals, in threefold strength,  
As all the valleys echoed through the night.  
The mighty heads stormbent, the branches tossed  
Into the sheets of water, sky and earth  
In lurid light, a never-ceasing flame.  
There in the grass, beneath a tiny leaf  
A firefly put forth its wondrous ray,  
As if no storm, no rain, no hail were nigh,  
A peaceful little flame, and yet so strong,  
That it outshone the lightning. It would say:  
I am the same as lightning! Storm thy life  
And threat'ning thunder, but thy flame O minstrel,  
Thy heart's own fire, is as strong, as true,  
As elementary as Fate's wild raving,  
And though it throws its light but on a leaf,  
That leaf may be eternal by the light  
Thy soul hath shed on it. That steady flame  
Burns on, when all the clouds have spent their fire,  
And when the bowels of the earth have ceased  
To growl in answer. Undisturbed, thy flame  
Will live, defying Fate's alarm, a fearless,  
Undying mighty word, as strong as lightning  
And love's own sheen, thy soul's unwavering beacon.

---

## A DREAM



**M**ETHOUGHT that unto God I prayed: Oh, Lord!  
If thou wouldst deign to let poor me behold  
Thy greatness, so that with my human brain  
I understood it! Thus I spoke, and Lo!  
I stood alone upon a mountain rock,  
In utter darkness, towering rocks beyond  
The dread abyss, that at my feet lay black  
And fathomless, yielding no answer to  
The searching eye. And, measureless, the sky  
Above was dark'ning into endless night.  
Then, from the deep did vapours seem to rise  
In white procession, denser, and yet denser,  
Until into a rising column they  
Began to form—a column like a mountain,  
That rose and rose and rose up to the vaults  
Of darkness which it seemed to carry, all  
One mass of light. And when I looked again,  
That column built itself of millions and  
Millions of milk-white stars that moved and shone  
And seemed to lift the skies unto a height  
That human sight and human word could not  
Attain. And whilst I looked and wondered at  
The seething worlds, the column changed and formed  
Itself into the statue Buonarroti  
Has made of Moses, only reaching from  
The deep into the heavens, white and bright,  
As if three suns, themselves invisible,  
Had shed their light upon the statue, or  
As if an inner light shone out from it.

The socle, not on earth, but far beyond,  
Was standing on the Parthenon, that shone  
As bright again with endless rows of columns.  
Here was the answer: Millions and yet millions  
Of rising worlds, and every people's art,  
And all religions may but serve to form  
My human likeness, so that men behold  
Me great as mortal eye and brain encompass.  
For days I walked on clouds, I lived my dream.  
I heard not, saw not, thought not, but beheld  
The world's Creator in the silent night,  
And felt the blessing so unspeakable  
Of God's own answer to my childish prayer.

---

## IN THE DARK



THE moon has but one side of light and beauty,  
The other, steeped in never-ending night,  
Seems worse than dead, as in the harmony  
Of spheres, she cannot even echo. And  
She died they say, for love of her great brother,  
The glorious Sun, whom she may never reach,  
Condemned to be apart, for that great sin  
Of love. He was the light and life and joy  
Of all her world, how could she then refrain  
And love not, when her brother was a god?  
But then she died, you see, and was forgiven.  
Wherefore is Earth so dark and yet alive?  
Wherefore doth fire still melt the gold in depths  
So fathomless, that not a spark may light  
The poor outside? She wanders through the worlds,  
Unknown, without a ray, and yet alive  
With foaming waters and with words as proud  
As flowing hair. Why art thou dark, O Earth?  
If thou wert sinless, would not dancing rays  
Laugh through the night and gladden other planets?  
Would not thy bosom's warmth give life again  
To yonder ghost, thy mate in misery?  
What hast thou done to be condemned to darkness,  
To be a living hell, wherein the souls  
Of millions suffer until death? Thy heart  
Is gold: hast thou betrayed the sun? Or hast  
Thou stolen wondrous goods, in gliding from  
The sun? Therefore is Death to be thy child,  
A curse to wander on thy lovely sides,

That oft are torn and ever motherly  
Will comfort the offender with her off'rings.  
Or art thou dark because thy womb must be  
The grave of all thy children, Mother Earth?

---



## THE SENTINEL



EACH flower is a sentinel of God,  
And ev'ry tree and ev'ry grassblade. Not  
An unseen little stem, but that will stand  
And wait and shine, and never ask wherefore  
It came and why it has to wither. Thou  
Art such a sentinel, O Heart! Thou hast  
To stand and bloom and love beside the others,  
And wither when thy work is done, the spot  
Being given to another, whereupon  
Thou standest. And that other heart is growing  
And blooming into life beneath thy shade,  
As strong as thine, as ruby-red as thine,  
To wither and to fall beneath the scythe,  
As thine has done. Why ask and why despair?  
Why not be happy with the sun, the dew,  
The other flowery hearts that, full of life  
Unfold their petals, which are deep like thine,  
And rich as thine? Ye are to be a glorious  
And many-coloured meadow. Is it not  
Enough? And must ye grumble? Must ye strive  
To take away the light and dew, that fall  
Not to your share? Behold the scythe! And sow  
Thy seed and ask not where it falls. The wind  
Of fate has carried it away, to place  
Another sentinel, as unknown, as  
Unsought for as thyself, in a far land,  
To live when thou art gone, to bloom into  
Some unexpected beauty with thy strength,  
Thy blood, the thoughts that were companions once

To thee and that the wind hath blown so far  
Away. Thou shalt not say unto thy seed:  
"Fly thither!" It obeyeth not thy will.  
Thou shalt not long to be another plant;  
Thy tragedy is useless, and thy will  
Is nought. With all thy strength thou art but what  
Is wanted—tree or grassblade—never ask  
Wherefore? Here is no answer. Fate itself  
Knows not wherefore it blows, or tells thee not,  
But takes thy noblest self to other climes  
And leaves thee to the scythe. Complain not! Mourn not!  
Long not to live another day, when thou  
Art called, but bow thy head without a sigh,  
In gentle acquiescence, sentinel!

---

## LETHE



WHEN dark thy childhood, tears and grief have filled  
Thy swelling heart, that understood too much,  
Yet not enough to be forgiving, when  
The sun was pale, and darkness lonely, when  
The fear of unknown evil made thy lips  
Turn cold, and wonder changed to horror, then  
To dumb despair, to childhood's hopelessness,  
More hopeless than old age's iron clutch  
Of unbelief, the shadow of the past  
Will cast a pall o'er all thy life, then say:  
Go down, Remembrance, into Lethe, go!  
When work was hard and sacrifice in vain,  
And stones were hurled at thee, thy flowers trodden  
Into the soil, that, soaked with all thy blood,  
Could not resist, and giving way would swallow  
Thy noblest thoughts, and teach thee to undo  
Thyself, gainsay thyself, as if a coward  
Were crouching on thy shoulders, making thee  
Believe that all thy heroism was  
A sham—then say: Go down to Lethe, Thought,  
And darken not the hour when I rise  
Out of myself, out of the past, into  
The open day of wide forgetfulness.  
When shame has crept into the rocky strength,  
Into the pure recess a spotless soul  
Had lent thee, and with fiery coals has burnt  
A mark no rivers wash away, no winds  
Can cool, that sends a shudder through thy heart,  
Like snakes of cold disgust, then say again:

Go down to Lethe, not to rise and sting.  
But when those eyes, that were thy sun, are shut,  
When blind with tears thy gaze hath yet behold  
The angel wings that carried through unknown  
Untold of space thy life, thy heart, thy hope—  
No Lethe then! And no forgetfulness!  
But open wide thy soul: It is the sun,  
The sun that sends its beauteous rays into  
The dark, into the cold, into the night  
And terror of thy life. If grief hath ploughed  
The soil, fear not! The corn is rising, young  
And green and full of hope; the sun hath called;  
The sun shines full into that heart that was  
So torn, so weak, that could not lift itself  
Unto the heavens. They are open now,  
Flooded with light; take not thine eyes away,  
Bend not thy look unto the earth again,  
But rise on shining wings toward the rays  
That draw thee, call thee, bear thee to the light!

---

## A DEBTOR



OH, do not say that thanklessness has been  
Thy sole reward! What? Wouldst thou be rewarded?  
When God had laid the gift into thy heart,  
Thy hand, upon the road thou hadst to tread?  
Lay all thy thanks before the feet of him  
Who did not shun thy help, thy gift, thy love,  
But bore the humiliation and the weakness,  
And bared his heart before thy human gaze,  
The heart where none but God e'er read the truth,  
The burning record of despair. Be humble,  
Thyself, and touch not roughly, where the wound  
Is open, see the beads of anguish on  
The furrowed brow, the tightdrawn lips, and hear  
The tremor in the whispered words, that roll  
So heavily from off the heart, and leave  
It crushed, sometimes for ever. Dost thou know  
What lifeblood it hath cost to speak to thee,  
What tortured nights have gone before, what cry  
Of anguish rose towards that God, who seemed  
So merciless to him and overkind  
To thee, allowing thee to be his angel,  
To answer when a living word of love  
Had to be spoken, and a hand put out to help.  
Make him forget what he has told thee,  
Let him not feel that thou hast not forgotten,  
But make him help thee in his turn, when thine  
The pain, the care, the fear; allow him then  
To tend thee, and to pay his debt to thy  
Humility, and to thy thankfulness.



## "VENGEANCE IS MINE," SAITH THE LORD



THOU wouldst not be avenged if thou hadst but  
Insight enough into the human heart,  
Into its frailty and its cowardice.

Thou wouldst not be avenged if thou but sawest  
How mad, how childish and how selfish are  
The helpless ones, that did thee harm because  
They thought—Ah! What then thought they! That  
perchance

You hated them, or trod them down, or took  
Their sun away; and e'en for love will they  
Destroy thee, meaning well with thee—so well,  
That they as lief would see thee dead, not to  
Belong to what they hate—thy work, thy friend,  
Thy strong ambition, or the gift that God  
Hath put into thy soul, that calleth thee  
Away to other heights and other temples,  
Then where they long have worshipped. They dislike  
Thy road, thy word, they call it strange and dark,  
And they would lead thee back to where they started  
So long ago with thee, and show the wrong  
Thou doest quite unwittingly. A sigh,  
A smile is all thine answer, but thy way  
Is chosen; then the hue and cry is raised  
Against thee, and thy staunchest friends will pile  
With eager hands the wood on which to burn  
Thy very soul, and not a tear will quench  
That fire, not a hand will save thee, for  
Thou art misunderstood, misjudged, despised,  
And hated by the friends, who once believed

In thee as in their God. And what revenge  
Could help thee? Falling back on thee, thy arm  
Struck to the ground, thy heart a desert, not  
Devastated to bloom again, but burnt  
To lava by your heart's own flame of vengeance.  
And if forgiveness be too great for thee,  
Go past, turn not thy head, speak not a word  
That cannot be recalled, and that will bar  
The road for ever, that will cut the cloth  
Between thy foes and thee. The present hour  
Hath made that foe, who may come back to thee,  
And see thy truth. Be great and say: I have  
No foe! I smile, and they are nought! A breath  
May lay them low, so low that they must call  
To me for help! Then is thy vengeance ripe!  
Give help with gentle pity. Feel that thou  
Art ready with a well of living waters,  
With flowers still more lovely than before.  
Keep down the flames that make thee a volcano.  
Let lovely warmth be all their strength. For thou  
Art called upon to love and not to hate,  
To help and not to punish, as thine eyes  
Are far too weak to see the consequence  
Of human anger. Even the volcano  
Is aimless, powerless, like Fate itself,  
And thou canst not be Fate. Ah! Be thou then  
A human heart amongst poor human hearts!

---



# NIGHT



O NIGHT! Thou friend of Thought, of Song, of winged  
Inspiration! So gentle is thy tread,  
Thy hand so soft, thy look so deep, the sea  
Is not so deep as thy mysterious gaze.  
Revealest thou what worlds have thought in distant,  
Unfathomable dream? Thou knowest wonders,  
And tellest them in whispers to the dreamer.  
Thou art alive with silence, gentle Night,  
The silence of the Past and of the Future,  
Of things untold, but not forgotten, dreams  
Unreal, yet full of burning truth, and clad  
In image, that they startle not our heart,  
Nor wake its nerveless beating till it sounds.  
In silence, wondrous Night, thou teachest what  
The noisy Day would never understand:  
Thou makest us descend into the mine  
Yet unexplored of our soul, that hoards  
The many destinies of thousand years  
And other thousand years it wandered through.  
Search in the darkness of that mine, behold!  
The gold that shineth forth into thine eyes,  
The treasures of those other lives that death  
Transformed and left them unremembered. In  
The stillness that surrounds thy search thy soul  
Will show thee all its strength and weakness, all  
Those errors that condemned it to another  
And yet another life, to die again,  
And rise again and wander, yet a stranger,  
Into the changing world, but laden with

The knowledge of the past it seems to learn  
And calls it history, perchance its own  
Forgotten past, the very person that  
It seemed to be. And now it wonders why  
That person acted so and erred and wrought  
Such destinies. And all the time it is  
Itself that learns itself. Neglect not dreams  
Nor call them worthless. Great the truths they bring,  
Revealed in sights and legendary lore.  
When understood they are a blessing. Learn  
To understand the vision's soul, the thought  
Which it conveys, the future it reveals,  
The past it fetches out of yonder mine  
Thy brain was far too tired or far too weak  
To search. When plunged in sleep that brain that now  
Is thine will listen and may learn such things  
Thy soul will tell, as never book or school  
Or present life will teach. Oh, blessed Night!  
Spread o'er my soul thy wings and carry me  
Into those worlds my brain can never reach!  
Fathom not memories, but let me feel  
At one with all those lights that lie upon  
Thy bosom, breathing, shining there in silence.

---

## ROUSED



SLUMBER not! Rest not! Dream not! Thou art called!  
The blast has rung out o'er thy living grave;  
The clouds that hung so low above thy head  
Poured out their flame into thy soul, and yet  
Left more, much more alive there than thou knewest of.  
Awake! the years stand at thy gate, and knock  
To call thee forth, the dead past comes to life,  
And drives thee, with its flood of whirling waters,  
Onward to action, not to idle dreaming.  
Arise! walk on those waves, for they will bear thee.  
Trust thine own strength, and tread the flakes of foam  
Lightly, with wingèd feet, with wingèd soul!  
And thou shalt see that gales have left untouched  
The springtime in thy heart, still breaking forth  
In admiration, thankfulness and love.  
Yes, not even love is quenched, and still undimmed  
Enthusiasm's banner waves on high above thee.  
Thou fearest the world? And what then is the world?  
The shadow of a cloud—no more. Thou wouldst not  
Suffer it to become a stone to crush thee?  
Up! Shake thy shining wings upon the Dawn,  
And laugh the world to shame. 'Tis but a pageant,  
A mockery; give up thy heart to life  
In all its fulness—never to the world!  
And though the world should crush thine heart and say  
"Behold! 'tis dust and ashes!"—though it scatter  
Those ashes to the winds—yet art thou still  
Pure and unconquerable, O my heart!  
Thou art of those to whom an open foe

Is but a friend disguised; to whom each blow  
Serves as a force to send thee ever higher,  
Far above yawning gulf and raging whirlpool.  
O heart of mine, be strong! Doubt not, for doubt  
Was ever the one deadly foe, whose toils  
Might strangle thee. Up! fight that monster, trample  
Its venom under foot. The hour has come  
For thee to step forth, young again and free,  
A new Sir Galahad, brave, pure and strong,  
Around whom angels hover as he stretches  
His spotless shield to meet the early rays  
Of Heaven's bright, cloudless, joyous Morning-sun!

---

## SADNESS



THY sadness is a leaden shroud, a rock  
Of Sisyphus, which thou must upward roll  
By night and day, on, on. Its downward rush  
Is no relief, no help, since it but seems  
Heavier at each fresh start. And still thy strength  
Is waning, and thy heart aches with the tears—  
The unshed tears that lie like stones upon it,  
While those that flowed are rivers in thy path—  
Unfathomable, fordless, dark and deep.  
These thou must wade, with all thy burdens—wade  
And sink with every step as 'twere thy last,  
And feel such deadly weakness seize on thee  
As though some raging fever laid thee low.  
Thy sadness is a Nessus robe, that clings  
In burning folds about thee, sears thy flesh,  
And eats into thy bones. 'Tis like a weapon  
A man turns on himself, whose wound nought heals,  
Since it is dealt against his inmost soul.  
If, then, through clouds of sadness, thou perceivest  
The world, well mayst thou say of it: 'Tis hell!  
For spring itself is dark, the birds' sweet carol  
Cheerless and dull, thy life a very desert,  
Where human faces pass like spectral visions,  
And gladness is a thing so clean forgotten,  
As if it ne'er had been—its very name  
Become a soundless word, a ghostly whisper!

---

## WHEN JOY IS DEAD



**B**E still! A corpse lies there, a poor dead thing,  
With upturned face, white-lipped, the haggard features,  
Whereon once played a smile that gladdened hearts,  
Now set and cold. Circled with black and sunken  
Are now the eyes where stars were wont to sparkle,  
And Fate has drawn deep lines between the brows,  
That but a short time since seemed arched for mischief,  
And full of childish mirth. Close to the temples  
The hair clings straight and dull and colourless.  
And it was golden once, like living rays,  
And waved about the head, a sunrise-halo!  
The hands are folded—rigid, waxen, cold,  
They that were once like rose-leaves, in whose veins  
The blood coursed swiftly, full of generous warmth  
And loving gifts, and flowers, and balm for sorrow.  
Cold are they now, as had they never yet  
Clasped children to the heart, nor with deft touch  
Broidered such fairy work, nor scattered broadcast  
Such fairy gifts. The feet that danced along,  
Leaving no trace upon the flower-petals,  
Lie stiff out-stretched, and round about them hang  
In heavy folds, as were they carved in marble,  
The robes that fluttered lightly in the breeze,  
Like opalescent wings.

Ah! cold and dark  
The grave to thee, thou Sun-child! ray of brightness!  
Beloved messenger of God! Arise!  
Canst thou be dead? and canst thou look so stern?  
Ah, no! not stern, but martyred! Cruel hands

Have rent thy garments, dragged thee by the hair,  
Burnt out thine eyes, and filled thy cup with poison,  
As fit requital of thy priceless gifts,  
Kind Joy, true friend! And now they see thee dead  
With careless eyes, and point, and feign to think  
Thou ne'er hast been! Ah, Joy! sweet Joy! arise!  
Be stronger than thy foes! But no! 'tis vain!  
Poor Joy was deadly tired, and now she sleeps!

---

## A ROOM



WHITEWASHED or panelled, filled with books, with  
light,  
With flowers, with trifles sacred to the heart,  
And work so pure and sweet that morning-dew  
Might settle there and feel itself at home  
As though 'mid garden fragrance; while the carol  
Of birds streams through the window joyously,  
Mistaking that abode of peace and love  
For their own woodland haunts! And in that room  
A woman's dainty hands ever at work,  
A woman's loving heart ever awake  
For others' happiness, a woman's thought  
Alive in tender memories that embalm  
The past in mute forgiveness. Enter then  
As 'twere a sanctuary, lay aside  
Thy load of care, and yield thy weary soul  
To the deep sense of comfort reigning there.  
Not many words—nay, not a single word—  
Need tremble through the stillness, not a sigh  
With untoward avowal break the peace  
That folds thee to its heart and asks no question.  
Such perfect peace pervades a room like this,  
'Twould seem the raging storm, the roaring sea,  
Might lay themselves to rest upon its threshold.  
The ghosts that haunt it come in guise of angels,  
With rosy finger-tips laid on their lips,  
To hush our voices to the whispered tones  
Of children's prayers. Enter, thou weary wanderer,  
Enter! and have no fear, for pain and anguish



Have long been wept away, and have but left  
Their precious perfume and the healing balm  
Of self-forgetfulness to comfort thee!

---

## UNREST



**T**O toss with fevered brain and throbbing pulses  
Upon thy bed at night—thine aching eyes,  
Straining into the darkness, hot and weary,  
Thy heart like lead, yet ever wildly bounding  
Within thee, like a gun made loose in shipwreck,  
That rolls from side to side, an unchained danger,  
Thy pillows fire, thy couch a rack, whereon  
Thy tortured limbs seem cords strung by the storm,  
Thy thoughts a tangled skein, unclear, disordered,  
And all the past that should have been forgotten  
Rising up ghostly, in fantastic guise,  
To make the present worse, to slay all hope,  
To quench the beacon that till now has been  
Thy only stay in night's deep gloom and horror!  
This, O my soul! is Unrest, and thou knowest  
Its misery but too well! All the old scars  
Of former battles bleed once more within thee,  
As if thy life were oozing, drop by drop.  
And thou wert fain with trembling fingers seize  
That foolish heart, and fling it in thy path  
To trample under foot, or, further still,  
Sink it in sea-depths, and then turn away  
Calm and indifferent, deeming all were well  
Were but its restlessness thus stilled, and thou  
Free from its tumult.

Yet that heart of thine  
Has weathered may a gale, and still might stand  
Unshaken at the helm of life's wrecked craft,  
A gallant pilot, waiting for the sign

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